SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #35 · TRUTH

“Church tradition carries the same authority as Scripture.”

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Where it often comes from

Growing up where long-standing customs were treated as unquestionable. Hearing “we’ve always done it this way” as if it were God’s command. Strong family or cultural ties to certain church practices. Not knowing where specific traditions came from. Christian traditions differ on how tradition and Scripture relate; this card focuses on the danger of letting any human tradition override God’s Word.

What Scripture teaches

Many church traditions are good and helpful: they can preserve wisdom, guard truth, and help us worship. But Jesus rebuked religious leaders for setting aside God’s commands to keep human traditions, and for nullifying God’s Word by their traditions. Scripture is God-breathed and stands forever. Traditions are valuable when they serve Scripture and must be corrected when they conflict with it.

> *“You have disregarded the commandment of God to keep the tradition of men”* **(Mark 7:8)**.

Also see

> “Thus you nullify the word of God by the tradition you have handed down. And you do so in many such matters” **(Mark 7:13)**.

> “All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for instruction, for conviction, for correction, and for training in righteousness, so that the man of God may be complete, fully equipped for every good work” **(2 Timothy 3:16–17)**.

> “The grass withers and the flowers fall, but the word of our God stands forever” **(Isaiah 40:8)**.

> “See to it that no one takes you captive through philosophy and empty deception, which are based on human tradition and the spiritual forces of the world rather than on Christ” **(Colossians 2:8)**.

Common self-statements

- If my church has always done it, God must require it.
- Questioning tradition is questioning God.
- Our customs are just as holy as the Bible.
- I’ll be in trouble with God if I don’t follow every tradition.
- Tradition is the same as truth.
- Changing anything is a betrayal.

Common logical errors

- **Confusing custom with command:** Treating human practices as if God commanded them.
- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Believing you must either keep every tradition or reject them all.
- **Appeal to age:** Assuming something is true because it is old.
- **Fear-based thinking:** Avoiding examination because change feels threatening.

Challenging questions

- What did Jesus say about traditions that set aside God's commands?
- Where did this tradition come from? Is it in Scripture?
- Does this tradition help me follow God's Word or replace it?
- Can I value tradition and still put Scripture first?
- What stands forever: God's Word or human customs?
- Am I afraid of God, or afraid of what people will think?
- Which traditions in my life truly draw me closer to God?

Truth summary

> Church traditions can be good gifts, but they do not carry the same authority as Scripture. God's Word is God-breathed and stands forever. I can honor traditions that help me follow Christ, and I can set aside any tradition that contradicts or replaces His Word.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Scripture/Word
- Truth
- Church
- Commandments
- Obedience

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Church tradition carries the same authority as Scripture"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Church tradition carries the same authority as Scripture." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What did Jesus say about traditions that replace God's commands?
- ☐ Where did this tradition come from?
- ☐ Does it help me follow God's Word or replace it?
- ☐ Can I value tradition and still put Scripture first?
- ☐ What stands forever?
- ☐ Am I afraid of God or of people?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God's Word has final authority.
- ☐ The word of our God stands forever.
- ☐ Traditions are good when they serve Scripture.
- ☐ I can honor helpful traditions without making them equal to the Bible.
- ☐ All Scripture is God-breathed.
- ☐ I follow Christ, not just customs.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Mark 7:8**
  "You have disregarded the commandment of God to keep the tradition of men."
- [ ] **Mark 7:13**
  "Thus you nullify the word of God by the tradition you have handed down. And you do so in many such matters."
- [ ] **2 Timothy 3:16–17**
  "All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for instruction, for conviction, for correction, and for training in righteousness, so that the man of God may be complete, fully equipped for every good work."
- [ ] **Isaiah 40:8**
  "The grass withers and the flowers fall, but the word of our God stands forever."
- [ ] **Colossians 2:8**
  "See to it that no one takes you captive through philosophy and empty deception, which are based on human tradition and the spiritual forces of the world rather than on Christ."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Tradition check:** List one tradition I practice, where it came from, and whether it helps me follow Scripture.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, John 8:31–32 becomes: "If **Sarah** continues in My word, **she** is truly My disciple. Then **she** will know the truth, and the truth will set **her** free."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Scripture/Word" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Choose one church tradition you follow** and research where it came from and what Scripture says about it.
- ☐ **Read Mark 7:1–13,** and write in your own words what Jesus was correcting.
- ☐ **Talk with your pastor or priest** about how your church understands tradition and Scripture.
- ☐ **Name one tradition that truly helps you draw near to God,** and thank Him for it.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Church tradition carries the same authority as Scripture": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One practice I checked against Scripture
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Church tradition carries the same authority as Scripture.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You for Your Word, which stands forever. Help me reject the lie that church tradition carries the same authority as Scripture. Thank You for traditions that help me worship and follow You. Give me wisdom to keep what is good and courage to put Your Word first. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.